‘Why not?’ Kaul exploded. ‘It was my definite order that the troops must be in position by the evening of 7th October.’ This was the first time any such order was being mentioned. ‘How dare you disobey my orders, you are the brigade major. I have given an assurance to the prime minister that I will carry out the operation. I am not a corps commander to sit in Shillong to conduct the operation. I intend to be present to conduct the operation myself.’ The corps commander throwing a tantrum in front of relatively junior officers could not have been a pretty sight. What was even more bizarre, Kaul literally bullied Kharbanda into ordering both 2 Rajput and 1/9 GR to move out of Lumpu on man pack basis (with just enough rations for a couple of days) and pouch ammunition.

Major Kharbanda, showing a lot more gumption than many other senior officers, suggested to Kaul that he should speak to his brigade commander before any troops were moved. Kaul again went ballistic, his every alternate sentence ending with ‘I shall get you dismissed’. Kharbanda then pointed out that there were no porters, to which Kaul replied that there was plenty of manpower in Tawang and that he would have them moved to Lumpu immediately. Rations would be no problem, for the general would arrange to have them airdropped at Tsangdhar immediately. Finally, Kharbanda pointed out that since the day was almost over, it would be better to move the two battalions in the early hours of 6 October. Kaul conceded that point. As the helicopter lifted off from Lumpu for Tezpur, Kaul could see the three officers standing next to the helipad—what he obviously could not see was the look of absolute despair and disbelief on their faces. The next morning, as darkness gave way to the grey dawn, 2 Rajput and 1/9 GR were on the move. On ‘bayonet strength and on a man pack basis’, few soldiers could even afford the luxury of a ground sheet, let alone a second blanket. Most men were still in the cotton uniforms that they had been surviving in ever since they left the plains almost three weeks ago. Even at Lumpu, which on paper was far better stocked, there was little that could be given to the men to battle the extreme cold. Now they were headed for Tsangdhar, two days’ march away, where there was even less by way of rations and stores.

The route to Tsangdhar from Lumpu was via the 16,000-foot Karpo-la 1, which was even more difficult than the route that traversed Hathung-la and connected with the lower reaches of the Nam Ka Chu. Since the Hathung-la route was under the observation of the Chinese, they had to take the Karpo-la 1 route. The gradient was almost vertical and the temperatures